

She was beautiful.

Nature always is.

But not in the way that we always imagine it - sunlight filtering through a brilliant, dense canopy of rich, rustling leaves.

No - She is dry branches, diverging as they reach for the ever-shining sky.

Her last leaves have long fallen, yet she is life.

Streaks of lichen paint her trunk lively hues of pastel greens. Mushroom clusters cling to her weathered spine in muted tones of cream, rust, and ash. Fresh, suede-soft, leathery, ruffled, brittle. They feed off of what she once was, what once had been.

Tunnels run through her core, meandering, bustling corridors winding, unseen, beneath her façade. Spiraling, vanishing into the depths of her marbled wood.

And in her quiet strength, she inspires music. Every sunrise, perched atop her tallest branch, a bird offers their lonely, lilting song to the world below, hoping someone might offer theirs in return.

Birds pull the moss that hangs gracefully from her branches, where leaves once grew. Squirrels selfishly snatch the mushrooms that define her trunk.

Yet she offers no protest.

She was beautiful in a way that only Mother Nature herself could capture, and only the greatest authors could aspire to. I offer still my humble ode to Her, who fought against the world -

Until the last wind blew.